CHAPTER 8

Strings

Computers, as I'm sure you are aware, are designed to manipulate numbers – in fact, they're brilliant at it, and it's why we invented them. However, a jobbing programmer (like yours truly) making their living on the good old internet tends to spend most of their working day handling text. Unless you're working in some financial sector, you likely won't have to perform very many numerical tasks, and those that do crop up tend to require a level of math you likely acquired around the age of eleven. (On one occasion in my career, I needed to implement some linear algebra, but it was over twenty years ago, hasn't happened again, and I didn't use PHP for it.)

In Chapter 7, "Numbers," we saw a variety of PHP features (both core and extended) for crunching numbers in lots of fun ways, and the good news is there are plenty of tools in the box for crunching text with PHP as well. Personally, I prefer PHP over many other languages for manipulating text, especially if I need to do so in the context of web applications. PHP was invented to make backend (hyper) text processing easier. It's literally in the name: "PHP: Hypertext Preprocessor" (admittedly a retcon but a good one). PHP isn't necessarily the quickest tool for some forms of string processing, but it has many features to make back-end web development less of a headache.

This chapter is a deep dive into all things concerning the handling of the `string` data type, which was introduced in Chapter 2, "Data, Types, and Variables," and has been used throughout the book so far in many of the code examples. If you haven't read that chapter yet, then I strongly recommend that you do; this chapter builds on the concepts discussed there. In this chapter we will cover the following topics:

- Creating strings
- Manipulating strings
- Operations and built-in functions
- Encoding
- Multi-byte strings

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